

among the reserves.

Bumrah's return for the first time since his World Cup final heroics is welcome, yet the pace cupboard looks bare. Arshdeep Singh has carried the attack in his absence, but if India fields both Varun Chakaravathy and Kuldeep Yadav on slower tracks, Arshdeep could miss out. Abhishek's part-time left-arm spin may soften that blow, but not entirely.

Despite some selection dilemmas, most bases appear covered. Batters now have defined roles thanks to position-specific choices, while the bowling mix will hinge on India's all-rounder puzzle.

The Asia Cup, staged in T20 format for the third time, is being marketed as a dress rehearsal for next year's World Cup. That comparison is misleading. The last T20 Asia Cup, also held in the UAE in 2022, saw only one 200-plus total in 13 games. Indian pitches will be far less forgiving for bowlers in the World Cup.

India, which last played a T20I in February, enters short on match practice.

JASPRIT BUMRAH MAKES HIS RETURN TO INDIA'S WHITE-BALL SETUP FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE THE 2024 T20 WORLD CUP



K. R. DEEPAK



SCHEDULE

September 9: **Group B** — Afghanistan vs Hong Kong
September 10: **Group A** — India vs UAE
September 11: **Group B** — Bangladesh vs Hong Kong
September 12: **Group A** — Pakistan vs Oman
September 13: **Group B** — Bangladesh vs Sri Lanka
September 14: **Group A** — India vs Pakistan
September 15: **Group A** — UAE vs Oman
September 15: **Group B** — Sri Lanka vs Hong Kong
September 16: **Group B** — Bangladesh vs Afghanistan
September 17: **Group A** — Pakistan vs UAE
September 18: **Group B** — Sri Lanka vs Afghanistan
September 19: **Group A** — India vs Oman

SUPER 4

September 20: **B1 vs B2**
September 21: **A1 vs A2**
September 23: **A2 vs B1**
September 24: **A1 vs B2**
September 25: **A2 vs B2**
September 26: **A1 vs B1**
September 28: **Final**